SIGNAL STATUS: UNRESOLVED

DEAD SIGNAL

ACT RUNDOWN AND TEAM WORKFLOW

PROJECT SNAPSHOT

A browser-based investigation played inside Mira Sen's fictional Windows-like workstation. The player follows a damaged session from login through file recovery, audio analysis, evidence review, and a final decision.

THE PLAYER JOURNEY

Explore the desktop. Collect clues. Verify system activity. Restore the recording. Decode the signal. Build the timeline. Recover the archive. Choose what happens to the evidence.

This guide follows the eight-act structure in the original team plan and incorporates the current build: charcoal Windows-style desktop, accessibility controls, app-based clues, a pinned Notes alphabet index, the recovered recording named AUD_0317.wav, and a player-created Evidence Board.

GUIDE AT A GLANCE	CURRENT GAME FLOW
Format	Single browser-based case; simulated computer and file recovery.
Player time	Designed for approximately 25-30 minutes.
Evidence path	Messages and Mail -> File Explorer and Recycle Bin -> Audio Lab and Notes -> Evidence Board -> Terminal.
Player agency	Three endings with different evidence and story outcomes.
Team plan	Person A owns the player shell and story-facing apps; Person B owns recovery and progression systems.

SPOILER-SAFE PUZZLE RULE

The archive key stays undisclosed in game text until the player records the four audio band numbers, pins Mira's alphabet key, converts the sequence, and submits both entries correctly.

01 / VISION

One computer, one investigation

Dead Signal should feel like Mira's workstation is still running after an interrupted session. Each application supplies evidence or changes what the player can access. The player can inspect the computer without interacting with real local files or executing real commands.

PLAYER LOOP

STAGE	WHAT THE PLAYER DOES	WHAT CHANGES
Explore	Open desktop apps and move between windows with the taskbar.	New clues and next-step guidance appear.
Collect	Read messages, mail, Notes, files, and system activity.	Evidence cards become available to pin.
Verify	Compare timestamps, deletion records, and network activity.	Connections create deductions and timeline progress.
Recover	Rebuild the recording name and restore the deleted recording.	Audio Lab becomes available.
Interpret	Listen to the signal and use the alphabet index.	The archive key becomes available after a correct match.
Decide	Recover the archive and choose an ending.	The investigation resolves according to player choices.

FICTIONAL OPERATING SYSTEM

APPLICATION	PLAYER-FACING PURPOSE
Desktop and window manager	Launch apps, arrange windows, switch focus, and follow the current objective.
Messages and Mail	Recover a timestamp, read warnings and drafts, and identify the recording reference.
File Explorer and Recycle Bin	Inspect properties and deleted metadata, rebuild a name, and restore files.
Notes and Audio Lab	Use the A=1 alphabet index with the audio band sequence; access transcript and visual alternatives.
System Monitor and Evidence Board	Review machine events and connect evidence cards into a timeline.
Terminal and Settings	Recover the final archive through simulated commands; control accessibility and hints.

SHARED SERVICES

The window shell, notifications, progression gates, save service, and hint service keep the applications in one consistent workflow.

02 / ACTS 1-2

Entry and orientation

ACT 1 | INTERRUPTED SESSION

Objective: Unlock Mira's workstation and establish that the previous session ended abnormally.

- Watch the recovery-mode boot sequence; allow the player to skip decorative animation.
- Use the date clue on the login screen to determine the workstation password.
- Offer text size, high contrast, and reduced motion before entering the desktop.
- Show the session recovery prompt, including the three files pending deletion; preserve a clear Continue path.
- Create the first automatic save after login.

> **ACT 1 OUTCOME**
> **The player reaches Mira's desktop with accessibility preferences applied and the interrupted-session warning established.**

ACT 2 | EXPLORING THE DESKTOP

Objective: Learn the workstation and locate the first suspicious material.

- Use desktop icons, the Start menu, notifications, and taskbar to open and switch apps.
- Read the Messages conversation and use the stopped workstation clock to restore Mira's missing timestamp.
- Open Mail and inspect the scheduled-wipe warning, the office-network warning, Mira's recording note, and the unsent draft.
- Open the damaged recording link in File Explorer. Use the month-first filename note and file date to rebuild AUD_0317.wav.
- Review Notification History when a clue-bearing toast has passed.
- Pin the first useful document to the Evidence Board.

> **ACT 2 OUTCOME**
> **Mail, Messages, File Explorer, Notes, the Evidence Board, and System Monitor form the investigation surface. A progress notice confirms discoveries; a guidance notice points to a useful next app.**

03 / ACTS 3-4

Contradiction and verification

ACT 3 | THE FIRST CONTRADICTION

Objective: Connect the company warning to Mira's late-night message.

- Compare the scheduled-wipe email with Mira's recovered message timestamp.
- Read the project note and unsent draft for the stakes and the missing archive clue.
- Place the warning email and meeting message on the Evidence Board and create a connection.
- Review the deduction produced by the connection; keep the finding in the player's evidence list.
- Continue to inspect recovered material while the machine acknowledges that the workstation may be watched.

> **ACT 3 OUTCOME**
> **The player has a reason to verify whether another person accessed Mira's computer; deleted-file metadata becomes useful.**

ACT 4 | SYSTEM MONITOR INVESTIGATION

Objective: Determine whether another person accessed the workstation and whether that activity overlaps the recording deletion.

- Inspect login, file, device, network, and process events in System Monitor.
- Compare the administrator session with Mira's recovered message time.
- Observe the unsigned observer service appear and later terminate remotely.
- Pin the administrator login, recording deletion, and blocked external-session events as evidence.
- Connect the deletion event to the blocked network session; connect the login event to the relevant meeting-time evidence.
- Use progressive, player-requested hints only when needed.

> **ACT 4 OUTCOME**
> **The event logs support a defensible explanation for how the recording was removed and why the external session matters.**

04 / ACTS 5-6

Recovery and audio forensics

ACT 5 | RECYCLE BIN RECOVERY

Objective: Reconstruct and restore Mira's deleted recording.

- Keep the Recycle Bin gated until the recording name has been identified.
- Inspect the deleted item's date, original location, file signature, checksum, and recovery state.
- Restore AUD_0317.wav to Recovered Files and save a checkpoint.
- Keep permanent deletion behind a confirmation; use the same protection across the Explorer, Recycle Bin, and simulated terminal routes.
- Unlock the Audio Lab only after the recording is restored.

> **ACT 5 OUTCOME**
> **AUD_0317.wav is available in Recovered Files, Audio Lab opens, and the recovered state survives reload.**

ACT 6 | AUDIO INVESTIGATION

Objective: Extract the signal sequence and use Mira's alphabet index to discover the archive key.

- Open Audio Lab after the recording is recovered. Playback, seek, volume, speed, filters, and markers remain available.
- Choose Voice, set playback to 0.75x, use the Enhanced transcript, and listen through the final signal segment.
- Read the numbered frequency bands in the visual display or use the equivalent written audio descriptions and captions.
- Open Notes and pin Mira's Alphabet key. The note defines the A=1 index without giving the decoded result.
- Enter the four band numbers in order, convert them through the pinned alphabet index, and submit both entries.
- Reject incomplete or incorrect entries with guidance that points to the missing step without showing the answer.
- Reveal the archive key only after both the band sequence and its alphabet conversion match.

> **ACT 6 OUTCOME**
> **The player has personally derived and verified the archive key. The Evidence Board receives the audio sequence and key deduction as separate, connectable clues.**

05 / ACTS 7-8

Timeline, archive, and endings

ACT 7 | RECONSTRUCTING THE TIMELINE

Objective: Turn individual clues into an ordered, defensible account.

- Open Notes, System Monitor, Mail, Messages, Audio Lab, and File Explorer to pin missing clues.
- Move Evidence Board cards and create connections directly; the player chooses each relationship.

Six relationships the evidence system can validate:

CLUE A	CLUE B	DEDUCTION
Scheduled wipe email	Mira's message timestamp	Mira kept investigating after the company warning.
Mira's message timestamp	Administrator login event	A privileged session began immediately before the message time.
Recording deletion event	Blocked external session event	The deletion overlaps the suspicious network session.
Mira's recording email	AUD_0317.wav filename clue	The email explains the damaged recording name.
Audio sequence recovered	Alphabet key from Notes	The signal sequence and index establish the archive key.
Archive-key deduction	Halden Group project clue	The decoded key points to the protected project archive.

- Review the generated timeline and pin the optional location note and external-session clue for the full trace ending.

> **ACT 7 OUTCOME**
> **The completed board identifies the hidden archive path and records which optional ending evidence has been found.**

ACT 8 | FINAL ARCHIVE RECOVERY

Objective: Recover the encrypted final message and decide what happens to the evidence.

- Open Terminal only after the Evidence Board timeline is complete.
- Use the fictional command set: help, open archive, unlock archive with the decoded key, and recover final_message.enc.
- When the remote deletion threat appears, use Protect Evidence in System Monitor or accept the consequences of waiting.
- Read the recovered message before choosing an ending.
- **Expose the truth:** send the evidence to journalist Dev Rao.
- **Erase everything:** permanently delete the investigation.
- **Trace Mira:** follow the location clue; requires the completed timeline, the external-session evidence, and Mira's pinned location note.

> **ACT 8 OUTCOME**
> **The ending reflects both the player's final choice and the state of the evidence preserved during the remote deletion sequence.**

06 / TEAM PLAN

Clear ownership, shared integration

PERSON A | PLAYER SHELL AND STORY-FACING FEATURES

FEATURE	DELIVERY
Boot and Login	Boot diagnostics, login clue, preferences, recovery prompt, desktop transition.
Desktop and Window Manager	Icons, taskbar, shared app windows, focus, drag, resize, minimize, maximize, close.
Mail and Messages	Inbox, drafts, conversations, attachment clues, timestamp puzzle, evidence actions.
Evidence Board	Movable cards, player-created links, pair validation, deductions, timeline state.
Dynamic Notifications	Queued alerts, categories, history, narrative reactions, progress and guidance.
Settings and Accessibility UI	Text size, contrast, motion, subtitles, volume, focus, hint preferences.
Ending Screens	Three outcome screens, eligibility display, restart and menu controls.
Testing and Documentation	Window, evidence, keyboard, accessibility, and player-flow coverage.

PERSON B | RECOVERY AND PROGRESSION SYSTEMS

FEATURE	DELIVERY
Explorer and Recycle Bin	Folders, properties, deleted items, filename reconstruction, validation, restoration.
Audio Lab	Playback, waveform, filters, transcript, signal bands, captions, visual alternative.
System Monitor	Login, file, device, process, and network activity; Protect Evidence.
Terminal and Archive	Limited fictional parser, help, history, unlock, recovery, invalid command handling.
Save and Resume	Shared state, checkpoints, migration, reset, backup recovery, malformed-save fallback.
Hints and Progression	Objective-aware hints, locks, act transitions, puzzle flags, ending eligibility.
Testing and Documentation	Recovery, audio, persistence, resume, progression, and technical notes.

07 / IMPLEMENTATION SCHEDULE

Five coordinated phases

PHASE	PERSON A	PERSON B	EXIT MILESTONE
1. Foundation	Login and desktop shell.	Game state and progression/save base.	Login, empty apps, resume.
2. First Investigation	Mail, Messages, notifications.	Explorer, Recycle Bin, filename rebuild.	Recording can be identified and restored.
3. Advanced Investigation	Evidence Board and deductions.	Audio Lab, System Monitor, hints.	Audio key and timeline are complete.
4. Finale	Settings, endings, final reactions.	Terminal, archive, ending requirements.	All three endings are reachable.
5. Integration and QA	Cross-test Person B; player-flow guide.	Cross-test Person A; technical notes.	Clean playthrough survives reloads.

INTEGRATION RHYTHM

- Agree on shared state fields and event names before dependent feature work begins.
- Integrate at the end of each phase rather than waiting until every application is complete.
- Demonstrate one playable path at every milestone, even while polish continues.
- Freeze new features during Phase 5 and use the remaining time for reliability and presentation.

SHARED RESPONSIBILITIES

AREA	PERSON A CONTRIBUTION	PERSON B CONTRIBUTION
Story	Character dialogue, emails, and messages.	System logs, audio transcript, and terminal text.
Accessibility	Shared styles, settings controls, and focus patterns.	Apply standards to recovery tools and audio alternatives.
Integration	Connect A-owned apps to shared state.	Connect B-owned apps to shared state.
Cross-testing	Test Person B features.	Test Person A features.
Presentation	Gameplay flow and visual design.	Architecture and technical demonstration.

CRITICAL PATH

KEEP THESE DEPENDENCIES CONNECTED

Mail clue -> damaged filename -> restored AUD_0317.wav -> audio band sequence and alphabet index -> completed timeline -> archive recovery -> ending.

08 / QUALITY GATES

Definition of done

Every feature is complete when its normal, locked, completed, and error states are usable; it reads and writes the shared game state; it can be operated by keyboard; and a reload restores the last saved checkpoint.

ACCESSIBILITY AND PLAYER SUPPORT

- Provide captions, a complete transcript, written signal descriptions, and a visual route for audio-dependent clues.
- Keep keyboard focus visible across the desktop, windows, dialogs, Evidence Board, Audio Lab, and Terminal.
- Support text scaling, high contrast, color-safe connection states, reduced motion, and independently adjustable audio.
- Keep essential information out of timed popups only; preserve clue-bearing alerts in Notification History.
- Make hints progressive and player-requested; let the player set hint frequency or turn hints off.
- Avoid rapid flashing and essential timed reactions. Pause the remote-deletion countdown when the game is hidden.

AUTOMATIC SAVE AND RESUME

- Save after login, major discoveries, file restoration, correct evidence links, audio verification, archive recovery, and ending selection.
- Preserve preferences, discovered evidence, links, restored files, viewed logs, notification history, and open-window layout.
- Recover a valid backup when the primary save is corrupt; offer a safe fresh session when both copies fail.

FINAL ACCEPTANCE CHECKLIST

CHECK	ACCEPTANCE RESULT
New player flow	A first-time player can finish the main path without developer assistance.
Clue integrity	No essential clue is lost when a toast closes, an item is deleted, or audio cannot be heard.
Audio puzzle	The key remains hidden until both the band sequence and alphabet conversion are correctly entered.
Endings	Each ending appears only when its stated requirements are satisfied.
Reload safety	Clean-start and resumed playthroughs survive reloads at every major checkpoint.
Cross-testing	Each person tests the other person's features and records unresolved issues.
Runtime boundary	The game simulates recovery and commands; it does not inspect local files or run real shell commands.

RECOMMENDED NEXT WORK

Finish cross-testing with a clean start, then repeat the critical path after reloads at login, recording restoration, audio verification, completed timeline, archive recovery, and ending selection.

Prepared from the project workflow and current repository behavior. Team hour allocations are intentionally omitted. The audio key is not printed in this guide.